

DM REFERENCE GUIDE

The Qilvayas Symphony

A quick-reference cheat sheet — Atlas, NPCs, and mythology at a glance

Living document — update alongside the sourcebook. Current through the full Social Foundations program — imperial law, language and literacy, currency, and medicine and disease all closed; Marked personhood and the Grey-Gold Rising the two live threads, both resolving at Solacre Day. Sessions 0–8; the Undercourt descent is complete.

THE ATLAS — REGIONS AT A GLANCE

Region	Ruler / Power	Disposition	Key Notes
The Crownlands	Direct imperial rule	Loyal (core)	Aenodira and its river valley; imperial law at full strength here only. INLAND — river trade via Rivergate, no ocean harbor (nearest salt water: Velmareth, 10 days downriver). Race-day factions: the Golds and the Greys.
The Ostmark	Legion garrisons; Magistrate Cassivar Ondrei (Dravenna); Marshal Gavric Dane	Loyal (towns) / inertial (country)	Colonel Aurel Dessen's grain scandal ongoing. Dane recovered the Ninth's lost standard — the legions' darling, the court's worry.
The Suthmark	Duke Aldous Vasq in law; the Dowager Duchess Emerenn (née Meldane) in fact	Loyal, devout, scarred	Feeds the capital. Carries the Vintage Night (6 yrs ago) and the Greywell disappearances.
Principality of Tarnovar	Voivode Ysavet Morn; Ban Dregan Morn (Eastmarch)	Independent (100 yrs)	DM ONLY: descended from Threnvos's people. Oath-culture; "Vosthren" ballads. Dregan's Fence holds the Brekeland border. Do not spend early.
Velmareth / Delta Compact	The Harborlords (incl. House Meldane)	Neutral / disorder-preferring	Merchant republic; Exchange delegations answer here. Meldane money reaches into the Suthmark.
The Brekelands	Warlords Bettra Skarn & Ilmarch Voss (shrinking)	Fractured / being absorbed	Granary War produced the Halvenne refugees. Squeezed between Norr's Reckoning Book (west) and Dregan's Fence (east).
The See of Orlath	Saint-Regent Olvesa the Reconciled	Schismatic — coronation pending	Founded ~58 yrs ago by Olvesa. Preparing to crown Karvel Emperor of the True Rite this Solacre (~9 mo out).
Kingdom of Ardven	King Karvel	Rival power (north)	Twelve crowns unified in 15 yrs. Monastery schools, working restoration. Olvesa's grandson; coronation imminent.
The Skellvard	Sea-King Aldrec the Landless	Hostile — but persuadable	Displaced ship-clans, pushed south by Ardven. Aldrec wants a march and a title; refused four times; dying slowly.
Duchy of Normere	Duke Garvin Norr, the Bastard	Rival power (west)	Conquest + the Reckoning Book + personal oaths. Absorbing the Brekelands. Qilvayas's dark mirror. The Harrowing of the Weld, 4 yrs ago.

IMPERIAL AND BORDER JURISDICTION, AT A GLANCE

Region	Legal Status	Who Enforces
The Crownlands	Direct Rule — imperial law at full strength	Palatine Guard; imperial magistrates

The Ostmark	Loyalist Provincial — nominal, unevenly enforced	Thin legion garrisons; Magistrate Ondrei's model
The Suthmark	Loyalist Provincial — genuinely loyal, ducal house	Duke Aldous in law; the Dowager's household authority in fact + the Church
Principality of Tarnovar	Sovereign Treaty-Nation — imperial law N/A	Oath-custom; the Voivode; Dregan's Fence (unsanctioned)
Velmareth / Delta Compact	Sovereign Treaty-Nation — own mercantile law; Marked hold legal standing here, uniquely	The Harborlords; the Compact's own courts
The Brekelands	Contested / Warlord — statute unenforced	Individual warlords; no appeal exists
The See of Orlath	Parallel Legal-Religious Authority	Olvesa's See; its own rival Sanction
Kingdom of Ardven	Sovereign Treaty-Nation — independent crown	King Karvel's own developing law
The Skellvard	Non-Territorial Customary Law	Clan lawspeakers; tally-sticks record debts
Duchy of Normere	De Facto Replacement — claimed, superseded	Norr's personal-oath system + the Reckoning Book

Marked (tiefling) personhood beyond Velmareth's exception: LIVE thread, not resolved by this pass — see Branch Ledger and Items/Threads. Book One's one clause the Commission hasn't closed; party action before the Solacre promulgation can tip it either way.

AENODIRA — DISTRICTS AT A GLANCE

District	Ring	What's There	Key Figure
Highcourt	Inner	Lupine Throne, ministries, the Long Course	Lord Chamberlain Vareth Kessin
The Sanctum	Inner	Great Temple, Office of Omens, clergy	Matriarch Ilsevet Corvane
The Old Forum	Inner	Ruins, Zhuvedus monument, catacombs	DM ONLY: confirmed site — the binding lies beneath (Undercourt)
Coppergate	Middle	Vaelindra's apartment, Ninth Lane	Vaelindra of the Still Waters
Scholar's Row	Middle	The Academy, restricted archives	Archivist Dathenor Vell
The Exchange	Middle	Guildhalls, merchant delegations	Guildmaster Ptolan Vess
The Garrison	Middle	Barracks, Palatine Guard HQ	Legate Bruvasca Thorne
The Archwork	Outer	Housing built into a bricked-up aqueduct	— working-class, unnamed
Farrowgate	Outer	Refugee/displaced quarter	— where Halvenne's people land if not resettled
Rivergate	Outer	Docks, river trade, document underworld	— Odric Hale's seal-dealer thread

KEY NPCs BY CIRCLE

THE IMPERIAL COURT

Name	Role	Notes
Emperor Qilvayas	110-yr-old Drow Emperor	Precise, quietly relentless, never raises his voice. Daily Draw of petitions. Has not entered his mother's study in 3 years. Sealed dispatch case in her cipher (canon — unopened; keyed by "the garden, not the grave").
Lord Chamberlain	Gatekeeper to the	Career bureaucrat; served Nyreeza first. Opinion of Qilvayas vs.

Vareth Kessin	Emperor	his mother never once stated.
Archjurist Senna Vhal	Head, Law Commission	Holds the pen on the Zhuvedian Laws. Battles Kessin over access, the provinces over every clause.
Legate Bruvasca Thorne	Commander, Palatine Guard	HISTORICAL KEY: Belisarius. The throne's one great commander (the Ashline, 800 vs. thousands). Beloved by the legions, mistrusted for it, never given the army she was made for. Husband Bram keeps the ledger of unkept promises. Holds Ondrei's complaint vs. Colonel Dessen.
Mistress Averil Shen	Bureau of Correspondence (spymaster)	Nyreeza's creature first. Only courtier who ran her own inquiry into the disappearance.
Hierophant Malzeth Corr	Head, Keepers of the Ascent (imperial cult)	Maintains the dynastic shrine at Highcourt; Qilvayas's relation to the cult is correct, not warm.

THE CHURCH

Name	Role	Notes
Matriarch Ilsevet Corvane	Voice of the Matron in Aenodira	Church's public face, not necessarily its supreme authority. Institution first, truth second.
Prelate Sarvin Odell	Head, Office of Omens	ACTIVE ANTAGONIST (S5–6): surveillance, summons, then the Writ of Examination vs. Vaelindra. Beatable by law or politics, never by argument. The copyist below Vaelindra reports to him.

THE ACADEMY

Name	Role	Notes
Archivist Dathenor Vell	Keeper of restricted stacks	Ancient, dry, volunteers nothing. Refers party to Vaelindra (Session 2). Knows why her Church career ended.
Professor Corvin Dail	Master of Trials	Designed the party's Proving. Praises by noting absence of error. Sat his own Proving 40 years ago.
Chancellor Emeth Sorral	Head of the Academy	Commencement-polish drops when surprised — the Cold Door does it. Knows the wards fail in the eastern stacks.
Instructor Liria Fenn	House of the Craft (stagecraft)	Plays "Merla" in the Proving. Warm and wicked once unmasked.

VAELINDRA OF THE STILL WATERS — THE SEERESS

Elderly human, ex-Church functionary sidelined after a vision the Church couldn't tolerate. Lives above a copyist's shop, Coppergate, Ninth Lane. Reframes the shared vision as potential, not prophecy. DM ONLY: her career-ending vision showed fragments of the true founding — Zhuvedus, the broken oath, Threnvos. She and Nyreeza discussed this in their final meeting; she believes Nyreeza went looking for the site itself. She believes Qilvayas risks repeating his ancestor's exact error.

SESSION 1–2 NPCs (THE OSTMARK AND THE ROAD)

Name	Location	Notes
Magistrate Cassivar Ondrei	Dravenna, the Ostmark	Precise, tired, provincial-honest. Renewable ally; his complaint re: the Third Legion colonel is now sitting with Thorne.
Yanna	Dravenna / the road	Teamster survivor. Recurring contact if treated kindly; hears things on the roads.
Sergeant Varkos Dren (deceased)	Redwatch	Session 1 antagonist — Oathbreaker deserter. His defaced, permanently cold medallion is now a party item.
Sgt. Petra Malich	Varn's Crossing checkpoint	Underpaid, privately ashamed of the illegal toll. Good soldier, bad arrangement.
Semya of Halvenne	The road / Farrowgate or Dravenna	Refugee matriarch; delivered the "indrawn breath" omen. Her people's fate tracks the party's choice to help or not.

Odric Hale	The road / Rivergate	Racketeer with a dead Roads Commission seal. Thread points to a Rivergate seal-dealer.
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THE POWERS OF THE FRACTURED EMPIRE

Name	Realm / Key	Notes
Sea-King Aldrec the Landless	Skellvard — Alaric I	Served the empire, betrayed at the Weeping Strait, refused a march four times. Wants IN. Dying slowly; the window closes with him. Tally-stick raids-as-collections.
Marshal Gavric Dane	Ostmark — Germanicus	"The Young Wolf." Recovered the Ninth's standard. Beloved, ambitionless, watched by everyone. DM: the Piso gun — if he dies suddenly, the empire tears itself apart. Never broken an oath.
Ban Dregan Morn	Tarnovar Eastmarch — Vlad III	Ex-academy hostage. The Fence: impaled oath-breakers; safest roads in the west. DM: closest of anyone to guessing the shadow's nature from first principles.
Duchess Emerenn Vasq	Suthmark — Catherine de' Medici	Velmareth Meldane by birth. Rules through sons + the Garland (informant web). Vintage Night truth (canon): a limited arrest that cascaded; she chose to own it. Waiting for the Ory accusation to become profitable.
Duke Aldous Vasq / Tavian Vasq	Suthmark — the ducal house	Aldous: 26, chronically ill, rules by signature and misses nothing. Tavian: 4 yrs younger, healthy, waiting. DM: the Denmother's Choice is revisable — that is the fault line.
Countess Velsanna Ory	Greywell, Suthmark — E. Báthory	GENUINELY MONSTROUS (canon ruling): blood-rite youth, 40+ girls over two decades. NOT shadow-connected — pure gothic horror. The crown owes her money; power will move for the debt, not the dead.
Saint-Regent Olvesa the Reconciled	See of Orlath — Olga of Kiev	Four vengeance, then sainthood. Founder of the See. DM: her visions are TRUE and darkened 3 yrs ago — that's why the coronation is now. Karvel's grandmother.
King Karvel	Ardven — Charlemagne	Unified twelve northern crowns; monastery schools; a restoration that works. Coronation as Emperor of the True Rite pending within the year — privately ambivalent about it.
Duke Garvin Norr	Normere — William the Conqueror	The Bastard. Reckoning Book + personal oaths + the Harrowing. Absorbing the Brekelands. DM: largest concentration of kept oaths alive — a single great betrayal by him would feed the shadow beyond anything since the fracture.

SESSIONS 5–6 NPCs (THE CAPITAL THREADS)

Name	Location / Role	Notes
Clerk Ossian Pell	Highcourt (Kessin's office)	Gray, forgettable, the party's barometer for Kessin's regard. Carried the first commission.
Tirell Mosse	Rivergate — Defunct & Antiquarian	Dealer in dead-office seals; mourns abolished institutions. Cultivated = document-underworld door; burned = door closed.
Brune Halloc	Rivergate docks — Inkhands boss	Violence as customer-service failure. Arrangement = friendly docks.
The Widow Brakka	Coppergate — company landlady	Feeds everyone, fears nothing, beat a mimic in negotiation. Load-bearing texture; protect at all costs.
Censor-Captain Ferrin Odo	The Sanctum — Office of Omens	Church soldier executing the Writ; nonlethal always; winnable by lawful conduct.
Ilinca Verath	Tarnovari envoy singer (optional)	Performs the Vosthren lament without knowing its truth. Friendly face of the future Tarnovar arc.
Professor Emeritus Pontellus Vorn	Roads / capital (optional, comic)	Expelled from three academies "for excessive rigor." Wrong about everything except one thing per appearance.

TITLES AND PRECEDENCE AT A GLANCE

Five ladders, not one. The empire keeps no single order of precedence — a Voivode and a Duke head different kinds of thing, not two rungs of one scale.

Ladder	Top to bottom	Note
Throne & Court	Emperor → Lord Chamberlain → Archjurist → Mistress/Master of a bureau → Magistrate	Precedence here is by ACCESS, not rank. Kessin commands nothing and outweighs almost everyone.
Legions	Legate → Colonel → Centurion → Sergeant → Legionary	Book Six. Marshal is an acclamation outside the ladder; Captain is a courtesy for irregulars.
Church	Matriarch + Synod of the Grey (collegial) Prelate Hierophant	NO supreme authority, by design. A Prelate holds his writ from the Synod — Odell is Corvane's colleague, not her subordinate. There is no head to appeal over.
Academy	Chancellor → Professor → Instructor; Archivist alongside	Professor Emeritus is kept for life regardless of how the post ended (see Vorn).
Sovereign / Border	King, Sea-King, Voivode, Ban, Duke/Duchess, Count/Countess, Lord, Harborlord, Guildmaster, Saint-Regent	These do not rank against each other at all. See below.

The distinction that matters: Norr's ducal title is IMPERIAL — granted by the Throne, making him on paper the Emperor's own subject running a rival restoration inside imperial law. Morn's Voivodate is FOREIGN and owes Aenodira nothing. A Voivode who defies the Throne is a neighbor; a Duke who does it is a precedent.

When ladders collide: Court = by access. Provinces = by force. Shrine = by rite. What happens when those disagree is deliberately unwritten — rule situationally and stay consistent.

Address: Emperor = Your Radiance / Majesty. King, Voivode, Sea-King, Duke, Duchess, Ban = Your Grace. Count, Countess, Lord = my lord / my lady. Matriarch = Your Voice. Prelate, Hierophant = Your Reverence. Olvesa = Mother (nothing grander, at her insistence). Legate, Marshal = the rank, plainly. Magistrate = Your Honor. Faculty = Professor / Instructor.

DM Only: Saint-Regent is the one title with teeth in it. The See holds the Lupine Throne vacant, which leaves a seat someone must keep — Olvesa has kept it sixty years. Karvel's coronation therefore ENDS her regency, purpose discharged. Play her as completing her life's work, not grasping at a new one.

MAGIC & FAITH AT A GLANCE

The Weight of the Word: Sworn words have literal metaphysical weight — the setting's signature. No mechanics; pure adjudicated flavor. Oath-breaking at scale scars ground (thin-written places: wards fail, divination sours, cold holds).

The Sanction: The Church licenses divine practice (pewter warrant-medals); the Matron answers everyone sincere regardless. Orlath runs a rival sanction. Unsanctioned healers = Office of Omens business.

Chartered Thaumaturgy: Arcane magic is credentialed and bureaucratic; hedge-mages tolerated till trouble; Rivergate sells unlicensed scrollwork. Sorcerers ('the Kindled') suspect; warlocks ('the Sworn') theologically radioactive — a pact is an oath that answered.

Night iconography: The She-Wolf of the Night Sky — moon her eye, stars her pack, liturgies sung at night. The coronation prayer is theologically literal.

Lycanthropy: Doctrine: profanation, hunted (wolf-trials). Folk belief: sometimes her mark. The gothic engine between the two is deliberate.

Wildshape: Doctrine-clean — no wolf-trial jurisdiction; willed shape isn't profanation. Office of Omens keeps a quiet interest-file on frequent/public shapeshifters anyway: leverage without threat, not persecution.

Wolf-Price: Self-defense = valid legal defense (report to a magistrate within 3 days, produce the body). Separate older custom: a debt to the local shrine-keeper regardless of guilt — reputation/plot hook, not legal jeopardy. Unpaid = worse than a magistrate's file, especially off the Crownlands.

Companions: Befriended wolf = the Matron's visible favor (social standing + Office interest); Beast Master ranger w/ wolf = the permanent version (touched in the provinces, on file in the capital); druids get wildshape instead, per doctrine. Caged/collared wolf = profanation-scandal. DM: wolves refuse thin-written ground — a companion wolf is a living Wardstone, and none will enter the Old Forum district.

Funerary custom: Universal night Vigil before disposal (doctrine-locked, every region — the Matron watches the dead home at night). After varies hard: Aenodira Bone Galleries (upper levels public; deep levels closed 'for consolidation' generations ago

— keeps funerals clear of the Session 6 route), Suthmark harvest-calendar burial, Tarnovar oath-inheritance over body-burial, Velmareth reed-sea barges. Any ordinary town: a Vigil Hall, whose keepers are the best-informed people in town.

Item economy: Arcana scarce/chartered; relics & blessed items flow through the faith (stamped potions 50 gp at almonries; false-relic trade in Rivergate). Wolves sacred everywhere; DM: Aenodira's wolves have been leaving the Old Forum for 3 years.

PEOPLES — QUICK REFERENCE

Drow — the Founder's Blood: Zhuvedus AND Threnvos both Drow (canon). Dynasty = his line, nearly alone. Any other Drow = enormous statement. OPEN: does Threnvos's line survive? (Do not spend early.)

Placement: Dwarves: Tarnovar (Stonesworn, ~1/3), Suthmark hills, capital masons. Wood elves: Old Wood + Ardven wilds. Half-orcs: Ostmark legion stock. Halflings: river trade/Coppergate. Gnomes: the Craft. Tieflings: the Marked (covenant-scarred lines). Dragonborn: Sarkanni mercenary lodges (contract-perfect, remarked upon).

Roster race calls: Vell hill dwarf; Mosse rock gnome; Halloc half-orc; Brakka dwarf; Vhal half-elf; Sorral half-elf (canon); Nyreeza Drow wizard. All Powers human; dynasty alone Drow.

DRAGONS OF THE FRACTURED AGE

Dragon	Where	The Short Version
Vessarkath the Patient	Silvasse Weald	Ancient green; TRUE author of the Silvasse Disaster; sleeps on the lost eagles; let Dane's standard leave — why now settled (DM): she felt the Acceleration. Receives; never treats.
The Saltmaw	Weeping Strait	Dragon turtle; the Skell pay the salt-tithe. Adopted option: it is what the admiral's squadrons fled — Aldrec's people were spent as distraction.
The Fjell Whites	Ardven ranges	Young white brood, ranger-culled; adult matriarch unconfirmed — the north's quiet dread and a ready escalation near the coronation.

THE ASPECTS — DOMAINS AT A GLANCE

Aspect	Domain	Serves	Note
The Watch at the Threshold	Life	Vigil-keepers, hospitallers, almoners	Commonest calling in the empire. Grave, if the table uses it, is the same Aspect darker: the Threshold-Wardens.
The Long Hunt	War	Legion chaplains, the Church militant	Endurance, not fury. The Matron does not sprint; she arrives.
The Long Memory	Knowledge	Archivists, jurists, the Office of Omens	She remembers every promise made in her hearing.
The Lamp Left Burning	Light	Vigil lamps, channel-lights, night offices	Light kept through the night, never sunrise. Orlath disputes the Aspect's standing.
The Elder Range	Nature	The Old Observance, druids, rangers	No icon: a bare stone, a marked tree. The Church's studied non-comment.
The Winter Voice	Tempest	Northern liturgies, Orlath, Ardven	The Sanctum finds it provincial. The north finds the Sanctum soft.
The Limping Bitch	Trickery	Nobody officially. Everybody provincially	Never recognized, never suppressed. Deception in defence of the den — the campaign's moral engine on a barn door.
(no Aspect)	Death	—	DM ONLY: the absence is doctrine. Divine power answering to death is not answering from the Matron, and the honest question of who does is open.
(no Aspect)	Arcana	—	Thaumaturgy is chartered, not blessed. A cleric of Arcana starts a decade-long jurisdictional war.

Paladin oaths: Devotion = Crown-sworn and the Church's Oathwards (Qilvayas). Ancients = the Green Watch, the Old Observance's unlicensed paladins. Vengeance = the Wolf-Price as vocation (Dregan Morn). DM ONLY — Oathbreaker is not a subclass here, it is the Founder's own road, and the thing beneath Aenodira notices immediately.

THE SAINTS — FEASTS AT A GLANCE

Feast	Saint	Patron Of
Wolfmoon 1	Lupenna of the First Shrine	Hospitality, guest-right. Her feast opens the year. The empire's two worst crimes are both guest-right violations.
Wolfmoon 4	Ivessa of the Ford	Rearguards and ferrymen. Three towns claim the ford; the Church has never adjudicated.
Thawtide 11	Coren the Unhurried	Vigil-keepers and night-workers. Four thousand nights; refused ordination six times.
Sowmonth 8	Yenna Corvane	Advocates. Lost four hundred cases deliberately to build the precedent. Vhal keeps a copy.
Sowmonth 27	Perisse the Milkless	Foundlings and the bound-freed. Cult strongest among the fourth tier.
Haymonth 9	Vosk the Field-Cutter	Surgeons. Refused to triage by rank; broken for it twice.
Harvestide 2	Bellara of Ambervale	Harvests and honest thieves. The Ambervale procession, and the route that changed.
Vinmoon 3	Ilvane the Sea-Kept	Pilots and merchants who honor a bad contract.
Fallowmonth 21	Halvard of the Quiet Rite	Stonewrights. Stonesworn; the Crownlands has never canonized him, which is a concession it will not make.
Greywane 14	Tobrin Ashfall	The falsely accused. The Church's uneasy conscience about the wolf-trial.
Greywane 30	Elleth of the Grey Gate	Gatekeepers. Venerated for the ones she turned away.
Longdark 19	Odarr of the Nine Winters	Winter travelers. Orlath claims him hardest.
Threshold 6	Marek the Witness	Witnesses and inconvenient truth. THE saint of the campaign's mechanism, and nobody has noticed.
suppressed	Ovric, Struck from the Canon	DM ONLY: struck ninety years ago because an archivist found what he witnessed. Touches the Founding. File is in the Archive's closed levels.

STANDING — FACTION TIERS

One number per faction, 0 to 5, moved by the DM at session end. Tier 2 grants advantage on Charisma checks against members; tier 3 opens the faction's own asset; tier 5 is a promise, and in this world a promise is a weight.

Faction	Rises When	Tier 3 Opens
Throne and Court	You make the restoration look competent, publicly	An audience without the Lord Chamberlain arranging it
The Church	You honor the Vigil; you resolve things it need not be seen to act on	Parish hospitality anywhere loyalist, and a sealed letter
The Office of Omens	You are useful to them	NOTHING GOOD — this score should be kept low and the players should not be told so
The Imperial Academy	Knowledge, students, or credit brought home	The deep stacks and an unquestioned requisition
The Law Commission	Evidence that survives a hearing	Vhal's ear and a Writ on a day's notice
The Legions	You stand where you said you would	A century who will listen; lost quartermaster paperwork

Merchants' Concord	A route made safer, a contract made enforceable	Credit, a factor in every town, the second-best network in the empire
The Inkhands	You pay, shut up, and bring no Watch	Unlicensed work at trade prices; a door out at any hour
Vaelindra's circle	You keep her confidence and your word	The others she has referred over fifty years
The See of Orlath	You treat the schism as a disagreement among the faithful	Northern passage and the Second Treasury
Tarnovar envoy	An oath kept at cost, where a Tarnovari sees it	A hearing at Kamenhold — nobody imperial has had one in a century
Golds / Greys	Seen at the Course, on a side, in bad weather	Three thousand people who will chant your name

Opposed pairs: Orlath vs. the Church. Vaelindra vs. the Office. Inkhands vs. the Law Commission. Tarnovar vs. the Court. Golds vs. Greys. Concord vs. the Legions. The Academy opposes nothing, which is why it is the best cover in the empire. The Church and the Throne are deliberately not opposed — the day one of them forces a choice is a campaign event.

KEYED LOCATIONS — WHERE TO LOOK

Dungeon / District	Areas	Document
The Undervault (three levels)	U1–U23	Sessions 3–4. Cipher Gate at U5, Registry Wall at U16, Cold Door at U18, Vault Nine at U22.
Redwatch	R1–R9	Session 1. Well and cistern at R4–R5 is the quiet way in; signal-tower puzzle at R9.
The approach to Aenodira	A1–A6	Session 2. Six beats over the last four miles.
Rivergate	V1–V9	Session 5. A district, not a corridor — any order, and V4 is skippable.
The Descent (Bone Galleries)	D1–D7	Session 6. Hoarding at D3 is a decision, not a lock.
The Undercourt	C1–C12	Sessions 7–8. Vesting Room at C2, Long Approach at C4, Witness Hall at C6, Rite Floor at C9.
The empire's thirty settlements	—	The Gazetteer, keyed six lines each with a named contact and a complication.

HOME BREW ITEMS OF RECORD

Dren's Oath-Medallion (uncommon, unique): Cold near oath-breaking, shadow-residue, thin-written ground. Quieter with oath-keepers.

Oathstone Charm (common, Kamenhold 5 gp): 1/day advantage on one Insight vs. a sworn statement.

Pilgrim's Wolfstone (common, Lupenna): Wolves/dogs neutral; true north on clear nights. ~1 in 40 'live'; the Church insists otherwise.

Wardstone Shard (common, unique source): Dim wolf-grey light 10 ft; gutters within 30 ft of Undercourt cold.

The Lector's Seal (rare, unique): Company stamp; academy-archive documents sealed with it read as authorized; unforgeable; every use logged in the deep stacks.

SOCIAL FOUNDATIONS AT A GLANCE

The Packlaw: Church doctrine — the Matron leads by wisdom, not strength; authority runs through mothers as often as sires. Explains why nearly every SETTLED seat of power (Nyreeza, Vasq, Morn, Corvane, Olvesa, Thorne, Shen) is female, while still-climbing/unsettled power (Norr, Karvel, Aldrec, Dane, Dregan) skews male. Bars no man from rule — Qilvayas sits the throne. His own unnamed heir is a quiet loose thread, deliberately unresolved.

Bound labor (4 tiers): (1) Chattel slavery: ILLEGAL + blasphemous empire-wide, tied to oath-magic (can't own what can swear). (2) Oath-bound service: legal (Norr's whole system). (3) Debt-bondage/indenture: legal, time-limited. (4) Hostage-diplomacy (incl. Academy admissions): separate category, NOT bondage, full legal personhood retained. Real crisis = enforcement gap in the Brekelands, not the law itself.

Marriage & the Denmother's Choice: Marriage = real oath (Church witness / Tarnovari standing stones); unrepaired infidelity/abandonment = a small echo of Zhuvedus's crime. Divorce = a formal Release (counter-oath), not just separation. Titled succession is NAMED, not automatic-eldest — revisable, doesn't require blood. Makes Vasq's Aldous/Tavian succession a genuinely open question. Tarnovar: title follows whoever takes up the stone. Suthmark: inheritance settles at Fallowmonth's turn.

The Marked's Legal Status: Feared/filed in Church lands, informally tolerated in Rivergate, full legal standing ONLY in Velmareth. Book One's one unresolved clause — deliberately LIVE, not closed. See Branch Ledger.

Currency — the Zhuven: Formal name for the standard gold coin (Zhuvedus obverse, She-Wolf reverse); everyone actually says "wolf" in Common. Silver strand, copper mote below it — inconsistent minting. Table pricing stays gp/sp/cp; Zhuven/strand/mote are just what the coins are called and look like in hand. Velmareth weighs rather than reads it; Norr restrikes captured coin with his own seal over the wolf; Tarnovar takes it same as anyone but trusts it less than a sworn word.

Language and Literacy: Old Imperial (dead as a native tongue, purely administrative/liturgical) vs. Common (universal vernacular). Literacy tracks education/office, not province — the party is a fluent, literate elite moving through a mostly unlettered world. Ardiven's subsidized literacy = ideological contrast; Tarnovar inverts the hierarchy (a spoken, witnessed oath outranks writing). Sharpened by the law pass: Books One–Four run on witness/mark/register, so the unlettered are exposed exactly where the Laws should protect them. Marked mapping: deliberately deferred to its own pass.

Medicine and Disease: Three certified tiers under Book Three (Sanction/divine, Charter/arcane, Crown-guild/mundane physicians) cover almost nobody — most of the empire relies on uncertified folk care (herbwife, bonesetter, midwife), same tolerance-tier as hedge-magic. Farrowgate's overcrowding breeds a chronic lung-ailment, the Damp — mundane, NOT shadow-connected (same ruling as Greywell). Church magic cures an active case instantly; it doesn't fix a drainage ditch. Rivergate sells patent quackery under forged Sanction marks.

The Imperial Calendar: 12 months, year begins Wolfmoon (Matron's month) — Thawtide, Sowmonth, Greening, Solacre, Haymonth, Harvestide (Vintage Night fell here), Vinmoon, Fallowmonth, Greywane, Longdark (Matron's 2nd month), Threshold (20-day year-end). Loyalists count Years of the Reckoning (YR) from the Founding; Orlath keeps a quiet second dating from the Reconciliation; Tarnovar counts by Voivodes' reigns.

THE ZHUVEDIAN LAWS — QUICK REFERENCE

Archjurist Vhal's Law Commission; promulgated together this coming Solacre on the Long Course. Seven Books:

Book One — Of Persons: Bound labor unchanged (see above) + NEW: an oath-bound service/indenture must be witnessed and recorded to be enforceable. Unwitnessed = not illegal, just unenforceable. Marked personhood generalized beyond Velmareth: LIVE Branch Ledger thread — see Branch Ledger and Items/Threads.

Book Two — Of Oaths and the Witness: States outright: an oath binds at law only if sworn before a recognized witness. Perjury = a distinct offense from lying, tried where the oath was sworn, penalized as a mark on the liar's own signet-record (Book Four), not a fine.

Book Three — Of the Sanction and the Charter: Certification = mark + register, always both. Church (Sanction), Charter (House of the Craft), Crown/guilds (mundane trade) each keep their own register. Unstamped/unlicensed = not itself a crime; shifts the burden to produce the register entry on challenge.

Book Four — Of Seals and Record: Forgery of an imperial instrument (seal/signet/writ/charter) = restitution + indenture, scaling to exile on repeat. A retired office must surrender its seal to the Archive before its authority lapses — how Mosse's trade is legitimate.

Book Five — Of the Wolf: Formalizes the existing Wolf-Price statute (see Magic & Faith, above) as statute. No new content.

Book Six — Of the March: Rank ladder: Legionary → Sergeant (~10) → Centurion (~80–100, NEW) → Colonel (a garrison/legion) → Legate (multi-legion / capital force). Censor / Censor-Captain leads Office Examiners. MARSHAL IS NOT A RANK — it's a Throne acclamation for personal renown, independent of command size (why Dane outranks Thorne in title but not in actual command). Officer misconduct = court-martial at Legate level, appealable once to Aenodira.

Book Seven — Of Judgment: No separate civilian watch — garrisons (Palatine Guard in Aenodira) double as the peace. Magistrates (Ondrei's model) are judge + civil administrator, no jury. Appeal to Aenodira exists but is slow. Secular process and the Church's Writ run in parallel and can conflict; a political favor can quash a writ as obstruction, but only as an exception. No magistrate, no appeal in warlord territory — the warlord's word is final.

CORE MYTHOLOGY AT A GLANCE (DM ONLY)

Zhuvedus: Empire's founder. Was a paladin, Oath of Devotion (canon). Broke a sworn covenant with his rival Threnvos, killing him under the Matron's own witness, and fell to Oathbreaker in the same act — the power that let him found the empire alone.

The Lupine Matron: The chief goddess, ancient, predates Zhuvedus and has guided many champions across history. Zhuvedus was simply the most successful. His own divinity is genuinely contested (three competing doctrines — see sourcebook).

Threnvos: Zhuvedus's rival and co-claimant, betrayed and destroyed. His people survive today as Tarnovar; "Vosthren" in their ballads is his name, syllable-inverted by drift.

The Shadow: Threnvos's dying essence fused with the impersonal force unleashed by the broken oath — personal grievance and impersonal hunger, born together. Fed since by every broken oath in the empire's 200-year fracture. NEVER state this to players; seed only in fragments.

The Binding Site: CONFIRMED CANON: beneath the Old Forum, in the Undercourt's deepest reach, touching the Academy's Undervault. Sessions 5–6 carry the party to the Second Seal at its threshold. Full site design beyond the Seal still pending.

Empress Nyreeza: Disappeared 3 years ago (timeline fixed). Working theory: she was investigating the true founding account and found the binding site, or evidence of it. Her cipher marks appear in the Undervault (Cold Door) and the wider Undercourt. Exact fate: still open by design.

The Proving: Real academy tradition — a staged final exam mistaken for reality by the cohort undergoing it. Subject of Sessions 3–4. Players must never hear the word before it happens.

TIMELINE AT A GLANCE

DM-only anchor (computational baseline; the in-world Reckoning figure stays soft and never appears player-facing): present day ≈ YR 2000, the founding at YR 0 — so every '~N years ago' resolves to YR (2000 – N).

When	Event
~2,000 yrs ago	The founding. Zhuvedus breaks the oath, destroys Threnvos. Binding site sealed. Threnvos's people scatter west → Tarnovar.
~200 yrs ago	The fracture begins; two centuries of provinces peeling away, feeding the shadow.
Across the 2 centuries	The Lupine Throne turns over faster than a Drow line should — fever, faction, twice to child-heirs and their regents; the court names a cause for each and never counts them. Nyreeza (own right, no regent) is the first steadiness in generations. DM: The Throne's Short Reigns.
~60 yrs ago	The Silvasse Disaster: three legions and their standards lost in the west.
~60–58 yrs ago	Olvesa's lord murdered; her four vengeance; her conversion; the See of Orlath founding itself around her (~58).
~50 yrs ago	Vaelindra's career-ending vision; quiet removal from the Church.
~40 yrs ago	Dregan Morn arrives at the academy as a Tarnovari hostage-student; stays past his studies, returns home a decade later.
~20 yrs ago	The Weeping Strait (Aldrec's betrayal). Norr takes Normere in fact.
~15 yrs ago	Karvel begins unifying Ardven; the Skell clans lose their fjords and turn south.
~12 yrs ago	Nyreeza begins the academy revival and institutional reforms.
11 yrs ago	Vell's last referral to Vaelindra — ended badly; hasn't presumed on her since.
6 yrs ago	The Vintage Night (Suthmark massacre of Orlathines; Vasq owns it).
4 yrs ago	The Harrowing of the Weld (Norr ends a rebellion, and a district).
3 yrs ago	Nyreeza's final meeting with Vaelindra; disappearance. Visions accelerate — Vaelindra's AND Olvesa's (which sets the coronation moving).
~3 yrs ago (DM)	Vessarkath lets one wolf-standard leave her hoard — she felt the stir under the capital; the Ninth's eagle starts its slow way home via the Brekelands.
~2.5 yrs ago	Qilvayas's coronation; restoration begins in earnest.
~1 yr ago	Marshal Dane recovers the Ninth's standard, nearly 60 yrs after Silvasse. The Ostmark's wound starts to close; the empire gets its Young Wolf.
This Solacre (~9 mo)	TWO CLOCKS, ONE DAY: Laws promulgation + Book One's Marked ruling + Book Three landing on Long Course commerce (Aenodira) + word of Karvel's coronation as Emperor of the True Rite (Orlath). One bell — see Solacre Day.
Present day	Party's field exercise → vision → return to Aenodira → the Proving.

ITEMS AND THREADS CURRENTLY IN PLAY

Dren's oath-medallion: Defaced, permanently cold, non-detectable as magical. First physical artifact of the truth. (Session 1)

The Cold Door rubbing: Charcoal rubbing of cipher marks at the Undervault's sealed door — now the only copy in existence; the wing was re-sealed after. (Sessions 3–4)

The Lector's Seal housing: Gifted to the party as their mercenary company's official sealing-stamp. (Sessions 3–4)

Forty witnesses (Halvenne): If resettled in Dravenna, a standing, grateful contact network. If not, they surface later in Farrowgate. (Session 2)

Ondrei's complaint vs. the Third Legion colonel: Currently sitting in Legate Thorne's inbox — background thread, can be developed or left as texture.

Solacre Day: The promulgation, the Marked ruling, the Grey-Gold Rising, and word of Karvel's coronation all converge on one day, not just one season. See The Coronation Clock and The Grey-Gold Rising, below.

The Coronation Clock: Karvel's crowning in Orlath, landing the same day as the Laws' promulgation — not merely the same year. The campaign's second structural clock.

The Landless King's Fifth Petition: Aldrec's final overture to the throne — a closing window tied to his failing health.

The Girls of Greywell: A Farrowgate family's missing daughter → Castle Greywell. Pure gothic horror, deliberately non-shadow.

The Grey-Gold Rising: Trigger reconciled: Book Three's registration requirement, extended over Long Course commerce — not a new tax. Golds (inner-wall patron money) and Greys (outer-wall trade) unite against enforcement that lands hardest on the Greys. Qilvayas's Nika moment. Mercy-or-massacre outcome LIVE, tracked on the Branch Ledger like Marked personhood — see Branch Ledger.

The Book and the Fence: Norr's surveyors approaching Dregan's stakes — the west's coming collision.

The Shen Alliance: Formed, discounted, or refused in Sessions 5–6 — defines the party's intelligence landscape. Shen holds Nyreeza's final filing; the party holds the rubbing; Vell holds the key.

The Empress's Last Words: Translated in Session 6: "the wound predates the Wall. The Tablets were written over it. He must not follow me. Tell him the garden, not the grave." The last line keys the sealed dispatch case.

The Writ's Aftermath: Vaelindra's status post-Session 6 (free/hidden/custody per branch) and every favor owed or spent to get there.

Marked Personhood — the Live Clause: Vhal's Commission hasn't settled Book One's treatment of the Marked; Velmareth's standing exception is the model on the table. Whatever the party brings to bear before the Solacre promulgation can tip the final language. If they never engage it, the Commission settles it without them.

The Second Seal: Reached, not opened, end of Session 6. The word FORGIVE. The campaign's fixed landmark going forward.

THE UNDERCOURT REVELATIONS (DM ONLY — SESSIONS 7–8)

Un-witnessing: Oaths bind because they are WITNESSED. The founding assembly turned away in unison — that unbinding is what made the betrayal possible. The shadow feeds on broken oaths AND the silence around them. Every institutional look-away is the same act.

The Vigil = the counter-rite: Witnessing starves it. The Vigil (watched, lit, never alone) is PENANCE, instituted by the witnesses' descendants — which is why it survives every schism unchanged. The party performed it correctly at Redwatch without being told.

The Golden Tablets: Composed BY the witnesses — the self-exoneration document of the people who looked away. "The Tablets were written over it." The law was the cover-up, written first.

Qilvayas's Laws = the weapon: A code making oaths enforceable, witnessed, and recorded is literal starvation for the entity. He built it by instinct, unknowing. The Daily Draw is the Emperor personally witnessing one citizen a day.

The Scouring — Emperor Vaskaren the Restorer (~200 yrs ago): Sought why the empire was failing, found the Hall, erased it. Second crime = same crime (un-witnessing by the founding's own family). His restoration failed; Qilvayas is the second restorer of that line. His order survives in the dynastic archive — how Nyreeza found the way down, and what waits in her sealed dispatch case.

The surviving frieze: Two spans missed on the eastern gallery's top tier. Identifiable faces + house-sigils; several of those houses sit at court today. The rubbing is a political bomb — publishing delegitimizes the throne, arms Orlath, vindicates Tarnovar, breaks the Church. Keeping quiet makes the party the newest witnesses to turn away.

Threnvos: Never received a Vigil. Present on the Rite Floor, speaks ONLY his half of the covenant — cannot answer questions, is not exposition. No stat block by design. Laying him to rest SEPARATES grief from hunger: real victory, not the victory.

What remains: The impersonal hunger — doesn't grieve, doesn't remember, can't be reasoned with (that part is now at rest). Fed by every broken word and averted eye. Campaign pivots from dungeon problem to civilization problem.

The Matron: May be down there keeping the vigil nobody else would. Divine magic works; clerics receive. NEVER a form, voice, or confirmation. Ambiguity is permanent and deliberate.

BRANCH LEDGER — RECORD THE PARTY'S DIVERGENCES

Every session module now carries a Diverging Paths section. Track outcomes here as they resolve; Sessions Seven and beyond are built against this ledger.

Divergence	Session	Outcome at Your Table / Effects
Deserters spared vs. killed (Dessen case strength)	1	
Parley vs. assault reputation	1	
Medallion carried, and by whom	1	
Semya's people: Dravenna vs. Farrowgate	2	
Malich respected vs. Ostrev's enmity	2	
Odric escorted vs. released (Mosse lead)	2	
Vision in the official report?	2	
Bloodless vs. bloody Proving (Highcourt read)	3–4	
Hound(s) freed / company animal	3–4	
Cold Door: what Sorral was told; rubbing shown?	3–4	
Kessin report: truth / cover / silence	5	
Odell interview: clean / attributed / registered / defied	5	
Mosse cultivated vs. burned; Inkhands arrangement	5	
Farrowgate client taken? (Greywell arc posture)	5	
The Writ: A law / B politics / C vanishing / D surrender / violence	6	
Translation shared with Shen: full / partial / none	6	
Throne told anything? (MAJOR GATE)	6	
Seal forced ("the Seal has heard them")?	6	
Envoy engaged (Tarnovar warmth)?	6	
The Seal-oath — who swore it, and the exact words	7	
Memory pressure — each character's unkept promise	7	
The Turned — witnessed vs. destroyed	7	
The frieze rubbing — taken or left; who argued	7	
The Vigil — kept / broken / refused	8	

Watch Three — who took the offer	8	
The covenant's second half — the players' words, verbatim	8	
WHO THEY TOLD (largest branch in the campaign)	8	
Marked personhood — Book One's final language	TBD (Twin Clocks)	
The Grey-Gold Rising — mercy or massacre	TBD (Twin Clocks)	

DELIBERATELY OPEN — BY DESIGN (NOT GAPS)

Nyreeza's exact fate — dead, transformed, or trapped: to be discovered through play. (The word FORGIVE at the Second Seal is her last known mark.)

Countess Ory's blood-rite mechanism — decide when the Greywell module is built (hag-bargain / fiendish compact / inherited rite).

The coronation's metaphysical consequence — a founding covenant sworn while the shadow listens: design when the arc approaches.

The Piso gun — whether Marshal Dane's sudden death ever occurs is a standing DM option, never an obligation.

The throne's short reigns — the Lupine line cannot hold its throne; mundane on the surface (fever, faction, regency), any deeper cause open by design. Do not resolve at the table.

What lies past the Second Seal — the next major build (see Roadmap).

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Update this guide whenever the sourcebook, session modules, or canon rulings change.